ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

*Meaning and Structure*

University of Glasgow

# Change in Meaning

**Marc Alexander**

Week 10

**1400s:** That peaceful serving boy made a fool out of their silly young goat's strength.

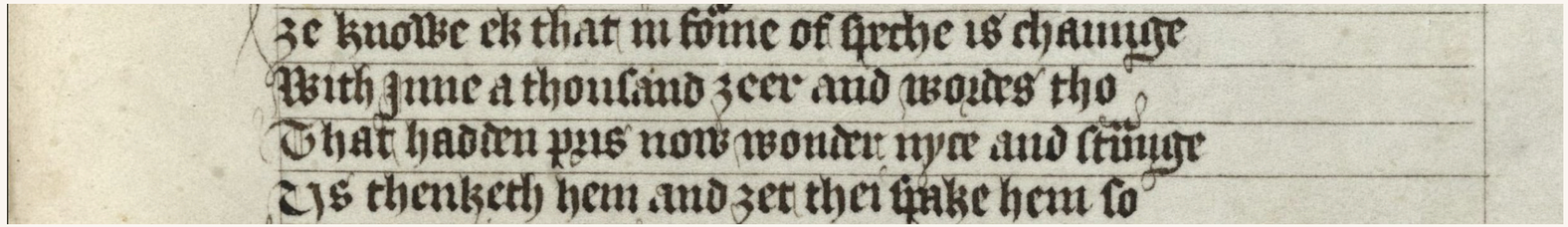
# The merry knight was fond of their nice kid's craft.

**Modern:** The cheerful warrior liked their pleasant child's skill.

No wonder is for it no thyng of newe is
A blynde man kan nat Iuggen wel in hewis

Ze knowe ek that in fōrme of speche is chaunge
With Inne a thousand zeer and wordes tho
That hadden pris now wonder nyce and straunge
Ds thenketh hem and zet thei spake hem so
And spedde as wel in loue as men now do
Ek forto wymmen loue in sondry ages
In sondry londes sondry ten vsages

And forth if it happe in any wyse
That here be any louere in this place
That herkneth as the storie wel devise
How Troilus cōme to his lady grace
And thenketh he wold ayen love purchace



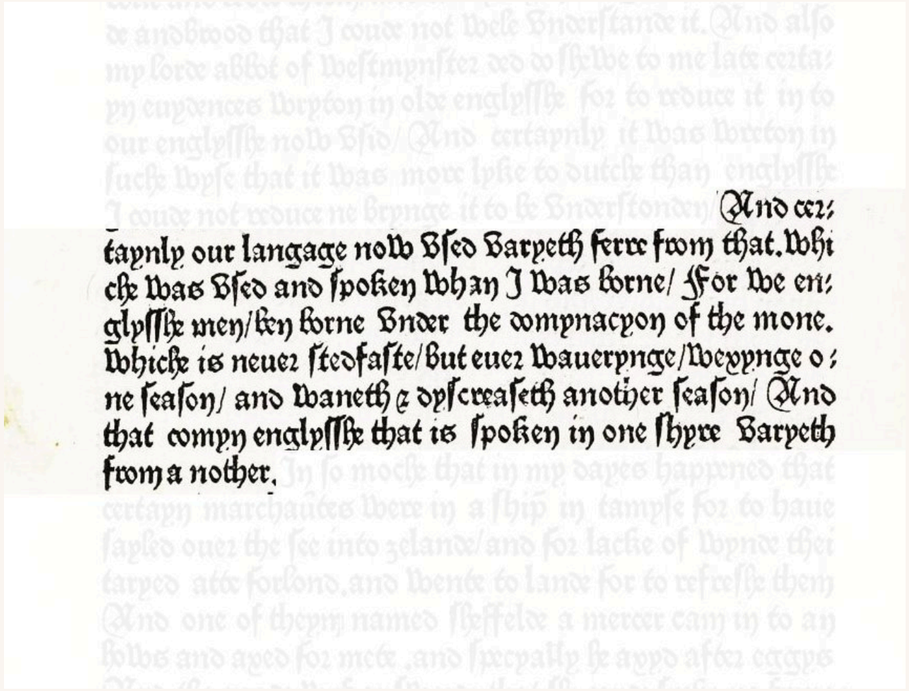

“

Ye knowe ek, that in forme of speche is chaunge
With inne a thousand yeer and wordes tho
That hadden prys, now wonder nyce and straunge
Us thinketh hem and yet thei spake hem so

[You know also that forms of speech will change
Within a thousand years, and words
That had a value, now wondrous silly and strange
We think them, they yet they spoke them so]

Chaucer, Geoffrey. c.1385. *Troilus and Criseyde*. Book II, lines 22-25.
Manuscript c. 1415-25: Cambridge, Corpus Christi College, MS 061, f. 149r

de and bwood that I coude not wele vnderstande it. And also
my lorde abbot of westmynster ded do shewe to me late certa:
yn euydences wryton in olde englysshe for to reduce it in to
our englysshe nowe vsid/ And certaynly it was wreton in
suche wyse that it was more lyke to dutche than englysshe
I coude not reduce ne brynge it to be vnderstonden/ And cer:
taynly our langage nowe vsed varyeth ferre from that. whi
che was vsed and spoken whan I was borne/ For we en:
glysshe men/ ben borne vnder the domynacyon of the mone.
Whiche is neuer stedfaste/ but euer wauerynge/ wexynge o:
ne season/ and waneth & dyscreaseth another season/ And
that comyn englysshe that is spoken in one shyre varyeth
from a nother. In so moche that in my dayes happened that
certayn marchaūtes were in a shippe in tamyse for to haue
sayled ouer the see into zelande/ and for lacke of wynde thei
taryed atte forlond. and wente to lande for to refreshe them
And one of theym named sheffelde a mercer cam in to an
hows and axed for mete. and specyally he axyd after eggys

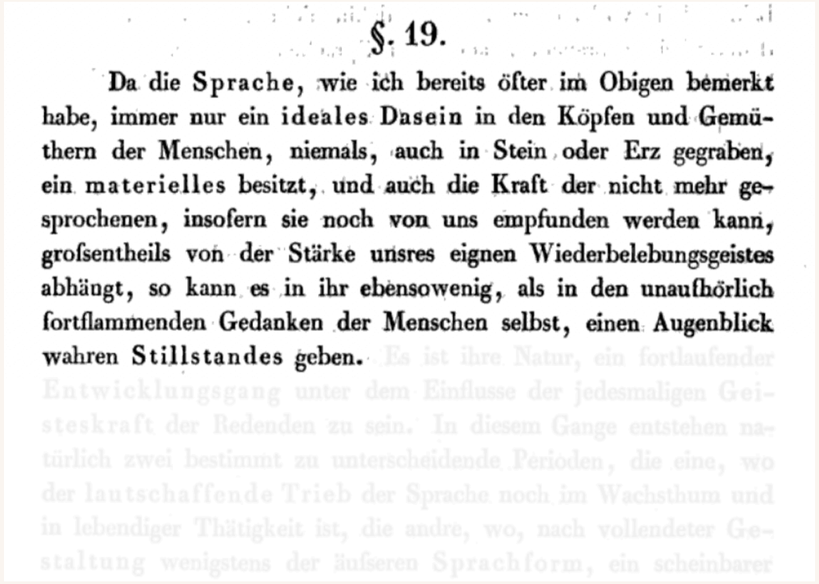


And certaynly our langage now vsed varyeth ferre from that. whiche was vsed and spoken whan I was borne / For we englysshe men / ben [are] borne vnder the domynacyon of the mone. whiche is neuer stedfaste / but euer wauerynge / wexynge one season / and waneth & dyscreaseth another season / And that comyn englisshe that is spoken in one shyre varyeth from a nother.

*Prologue*. Caxton, William. 1490. *Virgil's Booke of Eneydos*. London: Printed by William Caxton.

## §. 19.

Da die Sprache, wie ich bereits öfter im Obigen bemerkt habe, immer nur ein ideales Dasein in den Köpfen und Gemüthern der Menschen, niemals, auch in Stein oder Erz gegraben, ein materielles besitzt, und auch die Kraft der nicht mehr gesprochenen, insofern sie noch von uns empfunden werden kann, grofsentheils von der Stärke unsres eignen Wiederbelebungsgeistes abhängt, so kann es in ihr ebensowenig, als in den unaufhörlich fortflammenden Gedanken der Menschen selbst, einen Augenblick wahren Stillstandes geben. Es ist ihre Natur, ein fortlaufender Entwicklungsgang unter dem Einflusse der jedesmaligen Geisteskraft der Redenden zu sein. In diesem Gange entstehen natürlich zwei bestimmt zu unterscheidende Perioden, die eine, wo der lautschaffende Trieb der Sprache noch im Wachsthum und in lebendiger Thätigkeit ist, die andre, wo, nach vollendeter Gestaltung wenigstens der äufseren Sprachform, ein scheinbarer



§. 19.

Da die Sprache, wie ich bereits öfter im Obigen bemerkt habe, immer nur ein ideales Dasein in den Köpfen und Gemüthern der Menschen, niemals, auch in Stein oder Erz gegraben, ein materielles besitzt, und auch die Kraft der nicht mehr gesprochenen, insofern sie noch von uns empfunden werden kann, grofsentheils von der Stärke unsres eignen Wiederbelebungsgeistes abhängt, so kann es in ihr ebensowenig, als in den unaufhörlich fortflammenden Gedanken der Menschen selbst, einen Augenblick wahren Stillstandes geben.

“ Since language, as I have often noted above, always has only an ideal existence in the heads and minds of men, never a material one, even if engraved in stone or ore, and since the power of language that is no longer spoken, insofar as it can still be felt by us, depends largely on the strength of our own spirit of revival, there can be no moment of true standstill in it any more than in the ceaselessly flaming thoughts of men themselves.

von Humboldt, Wilhelm. 1836. *Über die Verschiedenheit des menschlichen Sprachbaues und ihren Einfluss auf die geistige Entwickelung des Menschengeschlechts* (=On the Diversity of Human Language Construction and Its Influence on the Mental Development of the Human Species). Berlin: F. Dümmler.

des rapports: [1280] le temps altère toutes choses; il n'y a pas de raison pour que la langue échappe à cette loi universelle.

D 225 [suite de 1300] SM III 129

[1280] Invoquons simplement ce fait que nous ne connaissons aucune chose qui ne s'altère dans le **temps.** [suite 1301]

**Première partie:** Immutabilité et mutabilité du signe 

III C 326 [suite de 1300]

[1280] ⟨Invoquons simplement ce fait que⟩ nous ne connaissons aucune chose qui ne s'altère dans le temps. [suite 1301]

III C 323 [suite de 1279]

[1281] Les étapes suivies jusqu'à la fin du chapitre sont les suivantes:

[1280] On peut se référer provisoirement à ce simple fait que toute espèce de chose [qui est] ⟨soumise au⟩ Temps se modifie, donc que la langue ou somme de rapports []. (⟨donc que la langue = somme des rapports entre le signifiant [].⟩) [suite 1301]

...time alters all things; there is no reason why language should escape this universal law.

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Let us simply invoke this fact that we know of no thing that does not change over time.

D 225 [suite de 1300] SM III 129

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(Let us simply invoke the fact that) we know of no thing that does not change over time.

III C 326 [suite de 1300]

[1280] ⟨Invoquons simplement ce fait que⟩ nous ne connaissons aucune chose qui ne s'altère dans le temps. [suite 1301]

We can refer provisionally to this simple fact that any kind of thing [which is] (subject to) Time is modified...

[1280] On peut se référer provisoirement à ce simple fait que toute espèce de chose [qui est] ⟨soumise au⟩ Temps se modifie, donc que la langue ou somme de rapports []. (⟨donc que la langue = somme des rapports entre le signifiant [].⟩) [suite 1301]

de Saussure, Ferdinand. 1916. *Cours de linguistique générale*. Eds. Charles Bally & Albert Sechehaye, with Albert Riedlinger. Paris: Payot.

de Saussure, Ferdinand. 1968–1974. *Cours de linguistique générale, édition critique*. Ed. Rudolf Engler. Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz.

# Semantic Change

- **Saussure:** “[…] time alters all things; there is no reason why language should escape this universal law.”
- **Sapir:** “Language moves down time in a current of its own making.”
- So words naturally change their meaning; language is not a fossil
- How do words change meaning?

**1400s:** The cold peasant was satisfied because her uneducated godparent looked truly skilful.

# The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**Modern:** The admirable scoundrel was sorrowful because her sexually-explicit rumours seemed intensely fake.

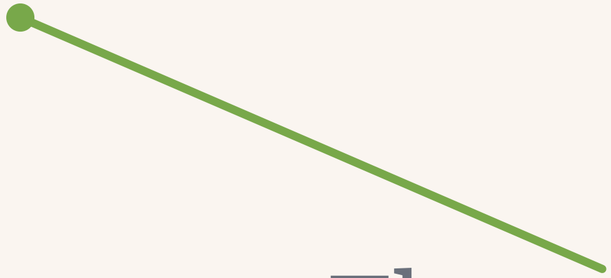
# Semantic Changes

Semantic changes are notoriously difficult to classify or systematize […] Additionally, semantic change is much more closely connected with change in the external, non-linguistic world, especially with developments in the spheres of culture and technology.

Durkin, Philip. 2009. *The Oxford Guide to Etymology*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 222–3.

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**cool:** cold → admirable



The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

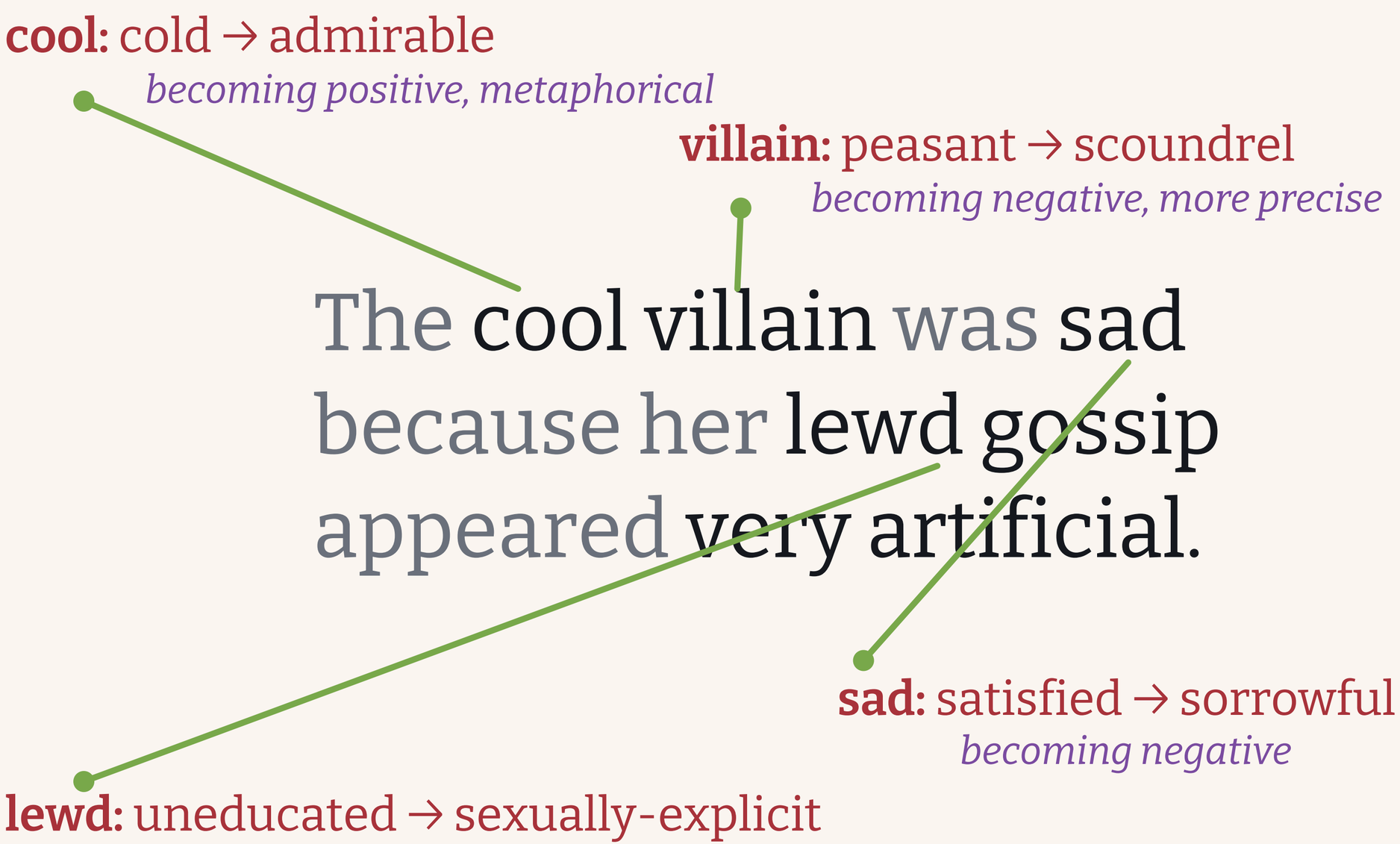

**cool:** cold → admirable
**villain:** peasant → scoundrel
The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.


**cool:** cold → admirable
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**lewd:** uneducated → sexually-explicit


**cool:** cold → admirable
*becoming positive, metaphorical*
**villain:** peasant → scoundrel
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**cool:** cold → admirable
*becoming positive, metaphorical*
**villain:** peasant → scoundrel
*becoming negative, more precise*
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**cool:** cold → admirable
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**sad:** satisfied → sorrowful
*becoming negative*
**lewd:** uneducated → sexually-explicit
*becoming negative*

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**gossip:** godparent → rumours



The cool villain was sad
because her lewd gossip
appeared very artificial.

**gossip:** godparent → rumours

*becoming negative, more general*



The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**gossip:** godparent → rumours

*becoming negative, more general*

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**very:** truly → intensely

**gossip:** godparent → rumours

*becoming negative, more general*

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**very:** truly → intensely

*becoming grammatical*

**gossip:** godparent → rumours

*becoming negative, more general*

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**very:** truly → intensely

*becoming grammatical*

**artificial:** skilful → fake

**gossip:** godparent → rumours

*becoming negative, more general*

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

**very:** truly → intensely

*becoming grammatical*

**artificial:** skilful → fake

*becoming negative*

# Types of Semantic Change

- Becoming positive (*cool*)
- Becoming negative (*sad*)
- Becoming more general (*gossip*)
- Becoming more precise (*villain*)
- Becoming grammatical (*very*)
- Metaphor and metonymy (*cool*)

# Amelioration and Pejoration

- **Amelioration** (or elevation): more positive
  - *nice* (foolish → pleasant)
  - *sophisticated* (artificial → refined)
  - *knight* (servant → nobleman)
- **Pejoration** (or deterioration): more negative
  - *silly* (blessed → foolish)
  - *vulgar* (common → crude)
  - *wench* (child → servant)

# Case Study: *silly*

| *Old English* | *Middle English* | *Early Modern English* | *Modern English* |
|---|---|---|---|
| happy | | | |
| fortunate | | | |
| blessed | → pious, holy | | |
| | innocent, harmless | | |
| | weak, pitiable | → simple, ignorant | |
| | | feeble-minded | → foolish, stupid |

# Broadening and Narrowing

- **Broadening** (or widening): more general
  - *dog* (specific breed → any canine)
  - *salary* (salt payment → any payment)
  - *bird* (small birds → all avian species)
- **Narrowing** (or specialization): more precise
  - *meat* (any food → animal flesh)
  - *deer* (any animal → specific species)
  - *starve* (any death → death by hunger)

# Grammaticalization

- Grammaticalization: becoming grammatical
- More precisely: content word → function word
  - *have to* lexical possession → modal obligation
  - *while* noun meaning ‘time’ → subordinating conjunction
  - *like* adjective meaning ‘similar’ → discourse marker, quotative
  - *because* PP ‘by cause’ → subordinating conjunction
  - *away* OE ‘on weg’, PP ‘on one’s way’ → adverb

# Metaphor and Metonymy

- Next week! Change through similarity and association:
  - *sweet* (taste → personality)
  - *sharp* (edge → intelligence)
  - *bitter* (taste → emotion)
  - *suits* (clothing → businesspeople)
  - *press* (machine → media)
- Can happen with whole domains:
  - In psychology, many physical metaphors (*depression, projection, defense, pressure, breakthrough, burnout, perspective, falling apart*)

# Chains

- Like with *silly*, these changes are often chained in complex ways:
  - *navigate* (sail a vessel → move between physical obstacles → move between figurative obstacles → use a website)
  - *awful* (inspiring awe → worthy of respect → impressive → frighteningly impressive → dreadful, monstrous → very bad)
  - *bully* (sweetheart → fine fellow → protector, champion → swaggering person → intimidator → harasser)
  - *heart* (organ → emotional centre → to love/like → like/favourite symbol → digital interaction)

# Why do meanings change?

- *External forces* such as new things in the world shift word meanings (so *wireless* meaning 📻 *radio*, common in the early and mid twentieth century, now often means technology without cords, as in ⌨️ *wireless keyboard*)
- *Internal forces* such as metaphor, or systemic regulation (OE/ON 👗 *skirt*/ 👚 *shirt*; homonymic clash in Northern English and Scots 🫘 *neer/kidney*, 👂 *ear/lug*)

# Evidence

## sophisticated

ADJECTIVE

Factsheet | Etymology | Meaning & use | Pronunciation | Frequency | Compounds & derived words

**QUOTATIONS**

Hide all quotations

**CONTENTS**

1. **Mixed with some foreign substance; adulterated; not pure or...**
2. Altered from, deprived of, primitive simplicity or...
3. Falsified in a greater or less degree; not plain, honest...

**EARLIER VERSION**

*sophisticated, ppl. a.* in OED Second Edition (1989)

**1.** Mixed with some foreign substance; adulterated; not pure or genuine. **1607–**

**1607** The drinke..they sweare Is wine sophisticated, that does runne Low on the lees of error.
T. Dekker, *Whore of Babylon* sig. H3$^{v}$ ...

**1651** They..have brought a great Odium upon it by carrying about, and vending..their sophisticated oils, & salts.
J. French, *Art of Distillation* To Reader sig. *4$^{v}$ ...

**1687** To give sophisticated Brewings vent.
M. Prior & Earl of Halifax, *Hind & Panther Transvers'd* 27 ...

**1806** The fraud is detected by adding alcohol to the sophisticated spirit.
W. Henry, *Epitome of Chemistry* (ed. 4) iii. ii. 376 ...

**1897** It is essential that water should be introduced, either pure or sophisticated.
T. C. Allbutt et al., *System of Medicine* vol. IV. 371 ...

Cite | Historical thesaurus

**2.a.** Altered from, deprived of, primitive simplicity or naturalness. Of a literary text: altered in the course of being copied or printed. **1603–**

# Evidence

- You should use OED citations to see examples in use (remember meanings exist only in use). So:
- *naughty*, adjective
  - Having or possessing nothing; poor, needy (c.1450 ‘More nedyer and nau3tier’)
  - Having no morals; morally bad or wicked (from C15th; 1677 ‘A most vile, flagitious man, a sorry and naughty Governour as could be’)
  - Sexually provocative (from C16th; 1675 ‘the naughty Town Women, who only hate their Husbands, and love every Man else’)
  - Mischevious or disobedient (from C17th; 1889 ‘behaves like a very naughty child’)

# Words and meanings

- There are approximately 3.4 *forms* for each *concept*, on average, over the last millennium of English (804,830 words and 235,249 meanings).
- We know this due to the *Historical Thesaurus of English* (ht.ac.uk), a research project at Glasgow since 1965, which arranges all the word forms in English according to their meaning.
- It is ‘a magnificent achievement of quite extraordinary value. It is perhaps the single most significant tool ever devised for investigating semantic, social, and intellectual history’ (Lord Randolph Quirk).

01 The world
02 The mind
03 Society
03.01 Society and the community
03.02 Inhabiting and dwelling
03.03 Armed hostility
03.04 Authority
03.05 Law
03.06 Morality
03.07 Education
03.08 Faith
03.09 Communication
03.10 Travel and travelling
03.10.01 Aspects of travel
03.10.02 Transport
03.10.03 Means of travel
03.10.04 Rail travel
03.10.05 Navigation
03.10.06 Air/space travel
03.11 Occupation and work
03.12 Trade and finance
03.13 Leisure

03.10.04 n.

# RAIL TRAVEL

PARTS OF SPEECH: n. Rail travel | adj. Of/pertaining to rail travel | adv. Rail travel | vi. Rail travel | vt. Rail travel

There are **4 words** at this level, sorted by first attested date:

**railroading** 1842– US

**railway travelling** 1842–

**rail travel** 1968–

**train travel** 1979

## SUBCATEGORIES

### 01 BY MONORAIL

Timeline Cite

**monorailing** 1962

### 02 WITHOUT PAYING

Timeline Cite

**train-jumping** 1965– orig. US

### 03 RIDING ON THE ROOF

Timeline Cite

**surfing** 1988

### 04 CHANGING FROM ONE TRAIN TO ANOTHER

Timeline Cite

**transhipment** 1899

### 05 A JOURNEY BY RAILWAY

Timeline Cite

**railway journey** 1864–

- 03.10.02 Transport
- 03.10.03 Means of travel
- 03.10.04 Rail travel
- 03.10.05 Navigation
- 03.10.06 Air/space travel
  - 03.10.06.01 Action of flying (in) aircraft
  - 03.10.06.02 Specific movements/positions of aircraft
  - 03.10.06.03 Transport by air
  - 03.10.06.04 Regulation and control of flying
  - 03.10.06.05 Airfield/airport
  - 03.10.06.06 Gliding and hang-gliding
  - 03.10.06.07 Ballooning
  - 03.10.06.08 Parachuting
  - 03.10.06.09 Use/science of rockets
  - 03.10.06.10 Space flight
  - 03.10.06.11 People who fly in aircraft/spacecraft
  - 03.10.06.12 A means of conveyance through the air
    - 03.10.06.12.01 Aeroplane
      - 03.10.06.12.01.01 Qualities and parameters of aircraft
      - 03.10.06.12.01.02 Parts of aircraft
        - 03.10.06.12.01.02.01 Controls and instruments
        - 03.10.06.12.01.02.02 Means of propulsion
    - 03.10.06.12.02 Glider
    - 03.10.06.12.03 Rotary wing aircraft
    - 03.10.06.12.04 Balloons and airships
    - 03.10.06.12.05 Kites
    - 03.10.06.12.06 Parachute
    - 03.10.06.12.07 Spacecraft

**gas balloon** 1881

## 01.01 TYPES OF BALLOON

Timeline Cite

**Montgolfier** 1784/5–1866

**fire-balloon** 1822–

**sausage** 1858–

**sausage balloon** 1874–

**hot-air balloon** 1905–

**observation balloon** 1909–

### 01.01.01 ATTACHED TO A WIRE

Timeline Cite

**kite-balloon** 1898

**sausage balloon** 1916–1930 slang

## 02 AIRSHIP

Timeline Cite

**ship** 1679–

**airship** 1819–

**dirigible** 1885–

**Zeppelin** 1900–

**aeronat** 1903–1908

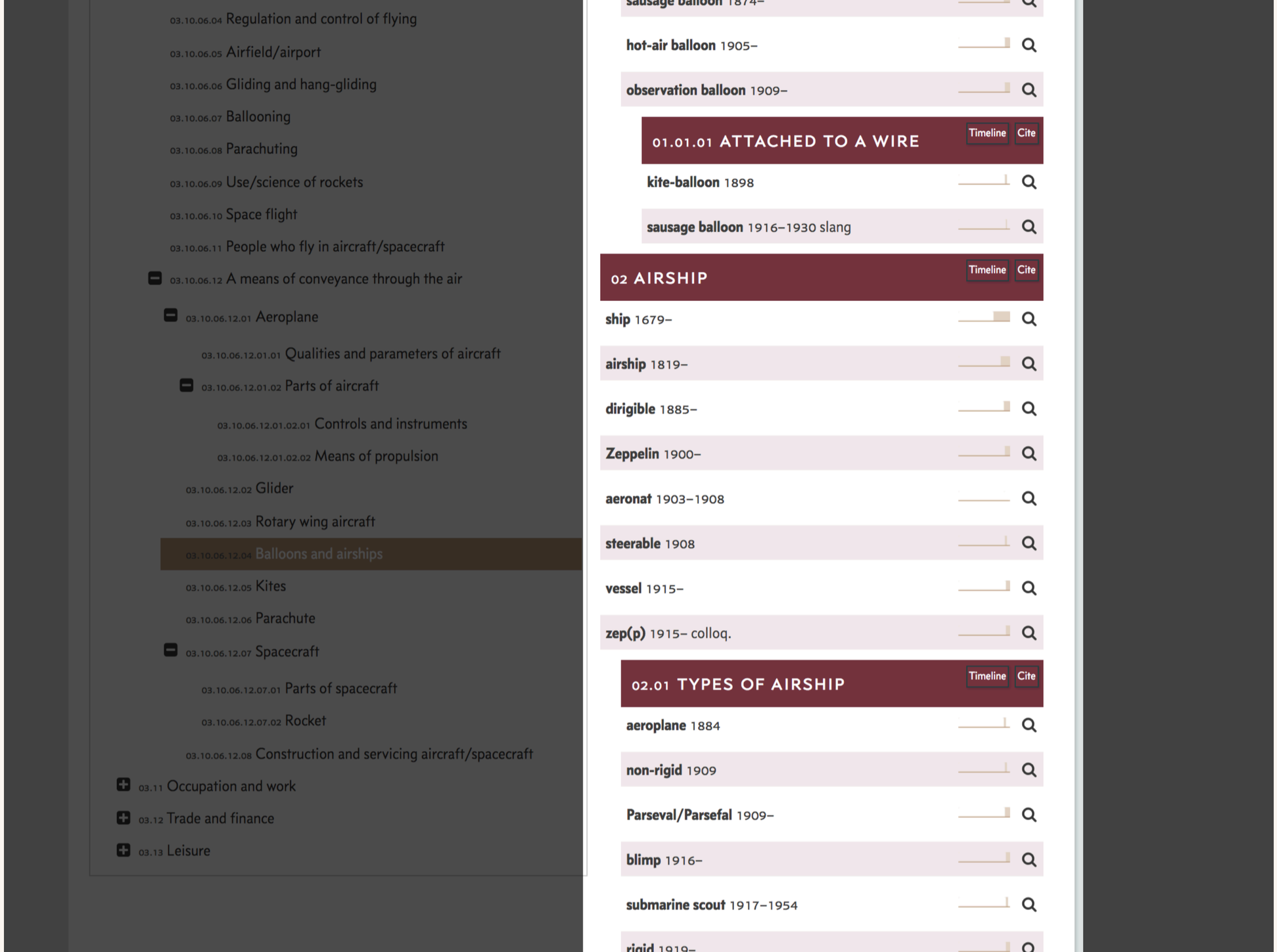
**steerable** 1908

**vessel** 1915–

**zep(p)** 1915– colloq.

### 02.01 TYPES OF AIRSHIP

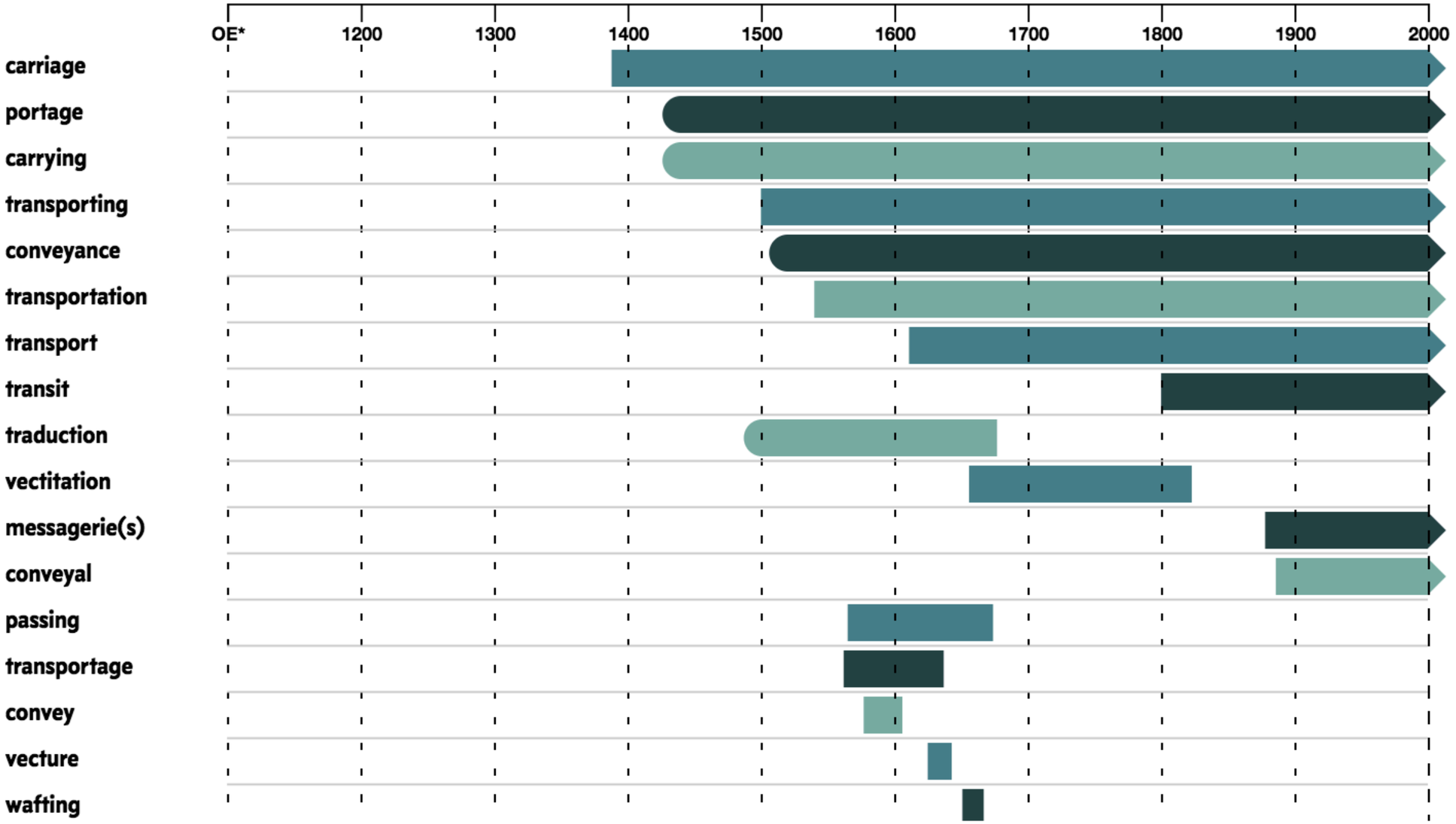
Timeline Cite


03.10.06.04 Regulation and control of flying
03.10.06.05 Airfield/airport
03.10.06.06 Gliding and hang-gliding
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03.10.06.12.07.01 Parts of spacecraft
03.10.06.12.07.02 Rocket
03.10.06.12.08 Construction and servicing aircraft/spacecraft
03.11 Occupation and work
03.12 Trade and finance
03.13 Leisure
sausage balloon 1874–
hot-air balloon 1905–
observation balloon 1909–
01.01.01 ATTACHED TO A WIRE
Timeline
Cite
kite-balloon 1898
sausage balloon 1916–1930 slang
02 AIRSHIP
Timeline
Cite
ship 1679–
airship 1819–
dirigible 1885–
Zeppelin 1900–
aeronat 1903–1908
steerable 1908
vessel 1915–
zep(p) 1915– colloq.
02.01 TYPES OF AIRSHIP
Timeline
Cite
aeroplane 1884
non-rigid 1909
Parseval/Parsefal 1909–
blimp 1916–
submarine scout 1917–1954
rigid 1919–

# 03.10.02 n. TRANSPORT

The timeline uses bars to represent stretches of time and circles for single dates. Select a bar or circle by clicking on it to see the underlyi

Sort by: First attested date | Alphabetically | Length of attestation



# THE HISTORICAL THESAURUS OF ENGLISH



The University of Glasgow's *Historical Thesaurus of English* is a unique resource charting the development of meaning in the huge and varied vocabulary of English. It consists of almost every recorded word in English from Anglo-Saxon times to the present day, all arranged into detailed hierarchies of meaning.

Of major interest to linguists, philologists, historians, philosophers, and the general reader, the *Historical Thesaurus* therefore maps the evolution of language, culture, and society throughout the English-speaking world. It is unique, both in its coverage and in its method; the data available through this online version enables users to pinpoint the range of meanings of a word throughout its history, explore a word's synonyms across time, and see the relationship of words to others of more general or more specific meaning. In addition to providing hitherto unavailable information for linguists, historians of language, authors, students of English, and textual scholars, the *Thesaurus* is a rich resource for investigating social and cultural history, showing the development of concepts through the shifting words used to describe them throughout the history of English.

The *Thesaurus* is primarily based on the *Oxford English Dictionary* with additional materials from *A Thesaurus of Old English*. The first edition was published in print as the *Historical Thesaurus of the* OED by Oxford University Press in 2009. The project was initiated by Professor Michael Samuels in 1965, the first edition *Thesaurus* was completed in 2008 under the direction of Professor Christian Kay, and its current director is Professor Marc Alexander. Work on a second edition is currently underway, and our updated material is released on this site as it becomes available.

## Quick Links

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The Queen's Anniversary Prizes For Higher and Further Education 2017

The University of Glasgow was awarded the Queen's Anniversary Prize for Higher Education in 2017 for its work in supporting the *Historical Thesaurus of English* for over fifty years.

## Sample Category

Pertaining to life in association with others > Pertaining to morals/morality > Morally evil > Of bad moral character >

**adj. Not magnanimous**

**[illegible]nimous** 1856–
**little** 1766–
**mean** 1665–
**ungenerous** 1641–

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# Recent Language Change

- Punctuation becoming lexical items:
- ‘Don’t *at* me.’
  - I’ve spent countless dollars on cushions and pillows that didn’t quite meet the approval of my neurotic hound mix, Leona, ending up shredded to pieces or, at best, ignored. Having a big pooch also means their furniture is going to be big, so you might as well pick an option or three (yes, Leona has three, don’t at me) you don’t hate looking at[…]
    *Architectural Digest,* ‘The Best Dog Beds for Your Furry Best Friend’, January 2024
- ‘He’s her boyfriend *slash* therapist’
  - One use: the first part intended versus the second part actual.
  - Another use: hesitation or blending. ‘It’s a library slash cafe’, ‘It’s strawberry slash tangerine or something?’

# Follow-up

- As well as general reading from the reading list, you should have a look at chapters 4 and 5 from:
  - Kay, Christian & Kathryn Allan. 2015. *English Historical Semantics*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press. (As always, available as an ebook via the library.)
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (email me for a time!)